

TIANLU ZHANG

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SUMMARY

- Mixed-methods UX researcher and PhD candidate with 2 years of industry UX research at Tencent.
- Proficient in framing product questions, research design, mixed-methods analysis, and actionable recommendations.
- Rich experience in communicating with academic and industrial partners and collaborating cross-functionally.
- Expert in leading multiple projects simultaneously and mentoring.

EDUCATION

The University of Texas at Austin

Ph.D., Developmental Psychology

M.S., Statistics

Austin, TX

04/2028

05/2027

- Coursework: Mathematical Statistics, Regression Analysis, Causal Inference, Scientific Machine Learning

Renmin University of China, M.A., Social Psychology

Beijing, China · 06/2022

Sun Yat-Sen University, B.A., Communication

Guangzhou, China · 06/2019

EXPERIENCE

Tencent, UX Researcher

Shenzhen, China · 06/2021 – 06/2023

- Led 10+ end-to-end research projects for Mobile QQ (social messaging) and QQ Metaverse (embedded social game), partnering with design, engineering, and product across 2 teams and balancing competing stakeholder priorities.
- Built **satisfaction/NPS measurement instruments** for each QQ Metaverse release cycle, iterating question design to capture user perceptions with validity and sensitivity across feature launches.
- Conducted **in-depth interviews** on user perceptions and acceptance of the **AIGC avatar** feature, identifying design integration strategies that balanced user experience with design productivity.
- Uncovered critical loading failures in the QQ Metaverse **AI render engine** by triangulating **survey** responses with **behavioral logs**; findings shaped the engine's product integration and deployment strategy.
- Diagnosed why **70% of QQ Metaverse users were inactive** by designing a comparative **survey study** of active vs. inactive segments; recommended a feature-exposure strategy that the product team adopted and shipped.
- Supported an in-person **usability test** of a mobile game prototype, observing live sessions to identify pain points, and facilitated a follow-up **focus group** to synthesize user suggestions into design iterations.

The University of Texas at Austin, Graduate Research Assistant

Austin, TX · 08/2023 – Present

- Design studies on how stress and family dynamics shape adolescent health, integrating **daily diaries, surveys, and 9 biological assays** from 600+ parent-adolescent dyads over 4 waves (10+ years).
- Evaluating a 10-session family intervention (20 intervention vs. 20 control dyads, 600+ pre/post assessments); proposed a **difference-in-differences design with Fisher randomization inference** to estimate effects in a small sample.
- Built **automated R and Python pipelines** for data cleaning, outlier flagging, and biomarker computation, producing reproducible datasets now used by all downstream lab projects.
- Compared **decision tree, random forest, and XGBoost** models to find top predictors of family-level depression profiles, surfacing patterns individual-level analysis misses.
- Published **10 peer-reviewed papers** (4 more under review); showed that daily stress increases and decreases have **asymmetric effects** on adolescent health, challenging a standard modeling assumption.
- Drafted methods and **power analyses** for 2 national grant applications; led 2 years of R workshops; mentor 2 students.

Austin Water, Data Science Intern

Austin, TX · 05/2025 – 08/2025

- Scoped and led a project with the conservation team to build **water-use benchmarks** for student housing, defining objectives, breaking the work into phases, and aligning stakeholders on a feasible plan.
- Applied **DBSCAN clustering** to 8 years of usage data across 10 properties to reveal distinct consumption profiles; **presented findings to stakeholders**, leading 8 additional properties to join the next phase.

SKILLS

UX research methods: Survey and instrument design, Interviews, Psychometric scale development, Behavioral log analysis, Usability testing, Focus groups, Daily diary and longitudinal designs, Sampling design.

Analytical Techniques: (M)ANOVA, Regression, SEM, Factor analysis, Bayesian estimation, Time series, Machine Learning methods (decision trees, random forests, XGBoost, clustering, PCA), causal inference models.

Tools: R, Python, SPSS, Mplus, Tableau, Git

Video channel: [Bilibili](#) (20k+ followers)